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Sora 2 Prompting Guide

This recipe is archived and may reference outdated models or APIs.



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Crafting a successful video prompt

Updated - March 2026

This guide has been updated to reflect the latest Sora API capabilities, including:

- **Character references (objects and animals)** – Upload a character once and reuse it across videos with consistent appearance.
- **Higher-resolution exports** – Generate videos in 1920×1080 or 1080×1920.
- **Longer videos** – Maximum duration increased from 12s to 20s.
- **Video extension** – Extend an existing video using the full initial clip as context, not just the last frame.
- **Batch API for video** – Run asynchronous video generation jobs for larger production workflows.

Before you prompt

Think of prompting like briefing a cinematographer who has never seen your storyboard. If you leave out details, they'll improvise – and you may not get what you envisioned. By being specific about what the “shot” should achieve, you give the model more control and consistency to work with.

But leaving some details open can be just as powerful. Giving the model more creative freedom can lead to surprising variations and unexpected, beautiful interpretations. Both approaches are valid: **detailed prompts give you control and consistency, while lighter prompts open space for creative outcomes.** The right

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- 1080x1920, 1920x1080

- **seconds**: the clip length, supported values: “4”, “8”, “12”, “16”, “20”. Default value is “4”.
- **characters** (*optional*): reference up to **two uploaded characters** in a generation. Each entry should include the character ID returned from the Characters API.

These parameters are the video’s container: resolution, duration, and character references will not change based on prose like “make it longer.” Set them explicitly in the API call; your prompt controls everything else (subject, motion, lighting, style). For more details, see the [Sora API docs](#).

Video Resolution

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Prompt anatomy that works

A clear prompt describes a shot as if you were sketching it onto a storyboard. State the camera framing, note depth of field, describe the action in beats, and set the lighting and palette. Anchoring your subject with a few distinctive details keeps it recognizable, while a single, plausible action makes the shot easier to follow.

Describing multiple shots in a single prompt is also valid if you need to cover a sequence. When you do this, keep each shot block distinct: one camera setup, one subject action, and one lighting recipe at a time. This gives you flexibility to generate short standalone clips or longer, continuous moments, depending on your project. Treat each shot as a creative unit, and you can either stitch them together in an edit or let them play out as a sequence in one go.

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Going Ultra-Detailed

For complex, cinematic shots, you can go beyond the standard prompt structure and specify the look, camera setup, grading, soundscape, and even shot rationale in professional production terms. This is similar to how a director briefs a camera crew or VFX team. Detailed cues for lensing, filtration, lighting, grading, and motion help the model lock onto a very specific aesthetic.

For example, you might describe **what the viewer notices first**, the **camera platform and lens**, **lighting direction**, **color palette**, **texture qualities**, **diegetic sound**, and **shot timing**. This approach works well when you want to match real cinematography styles (e.g., IMAX aerials, 35mm handheld, vintage 16mm documentary) or maintain strict continuity across shots.

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27 Main subject: mid-30s traveler, navy coat, backpack slung
on one shoulder, holding phone loosely at side.

28 Extras: commuters in muted tones; one cyclist pushing bike.

29 Props: paper coffee cup, rolling luggage, LED departure
board (generic destinations).

30

31 Sound

32 Diegetic only: faint rail screech, train brakes hiss,
distant announcement muffled (-20 LUFS), low ambient hum.

33 Footsteps and paper rustle; no score or added foley.

34

35 Optimized Shot List (2 shots / 4 s total)

36

37 0.00-2.40 - "Arrival Drift" (32 mm, shoulder-mounted slow
dolly left)

38 Camera slides past platform signage edge; shallow focus
reveals traveler mid-frame looking down tracks. Morning
light blooms across lens; train headlights flare softly

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1970s film, epic, IMAX scale scene, or 10mm black and white film sets a visual tone that frames all other choices. Establish this style early so the model can carry it through consistently.

The same details will read very differently depending on whether you call for a polished Hollywood drama, a handheld smartphone clip, or a grainy vintage commercial. Once the tone is set, layer in specifics with shot, action, and light.

Clarity wins. Instead of vague cues like *“a beautiful street,”* write *“wet asphalt, zebra crosswalk, neon sign reflection.”* Instead of *“moves quickly,”* specify *“jogs three steps and stops at the curb.”* Verbs and nouns that point to visible results will always give you a clearer, more consistent output.

Weak prompt

Strong prompt

“A beautiful street at night”

“Wet asphalt, zebra crosswalk, neon signs reflecting in puddles”

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Lighting + palette: warm backlight with soft rim

Some examples for good framing instructions:

- wide establishing shot, eye level
- wide shot, tracking left to right with the charge
- aerial wide shot, slight downward angle
- medium close-up shot, slight angle from behind

Some examples for good camera motion instructions:

- slowly tilting camera
- handheld eng camera

Control motion and timing

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of a broad note like “brightly lit room,” specify the mix of sources and tones: “soft window light with a warm lamp fill and a cool edge from the hallway.” Naming three to five colors helps keep the palette stable across shots.

Weak

Lighting + palette: brightly lit room



Strong

Lighting + palette: soft window light with warm lamp fill, cool rim from hallway

Palette anchors: amber, cream, walnut brown



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Prompt: *She turns around and smiles, then slowly walks out of the frame."*



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Prompt: *"The fridge door opens. A cute, chubby purple monster comes out of it."*

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Single bare bulb dangles from the ceiling, its light pooling onto the scarred metal table at the center. Two chairs face each other across it. On one side sits the Detective, trench coat draped across the back of his chair, eyes sharp and unblinking. Across from him, the Suspect slouches, cigarette smoke curling lazily toward the ceiling. The silence presses in, broken only by the faint hum of the overhead light.

Dialogue:

- Detective: "You're lying. I can hear it in your silence."
- Suspect: "Or maybe I'm just tired of talking."
- Detective: "Either way, you'll talk before the night's over."

Example description of background sound:

The hum of espresso machines and the murmur of voices form the



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Original Video



Edit prompt: "A second monster comes out right after"

Characters

The Characters API lets you create reusable characters from short reference videos. Once created, a character can be reused in future generations to keep appearance

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Below are three generated GIF examples using an uploaded character of a dog named Alfie. The leftmost video is the original reference used to create the character

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One effective way to write prompts is to separate the different kinds of information you want the model to use. This is **not a one-size-fits-all recipe for success**, but it gives you a clear framework and makes it easier to be consistent. Not every detail needs to be included – if something doesn't matter for the shot, you can leave it out.

In fact, **leaving certain elements open-ended will encourage the model to be more creative**. The less tightly you specify every visual choice, the more room the model has to interpret and surprise you with unexpected but often beautiful variations. Highly descriptive prompts yield more consistent, controlled results, while lighter prompts can unlock diverse outcomes that feel fresh and imaginative. Descriptive Prompt Template:

[Prose scene description in plain language. Describe characters, costumes, scenery, weather and other details. Be as descriptive to generate a video that matches your vision.]



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and yellowing blueprints. At the center, a small round robot sits on a wooden bench, its dented body patched with mismatched plates and old paint layers. Its large glowing eyes flicker pale blue as it fiddles nervously with a humming light bulb. The air hums with quiet mechanical whirs, rain patters on the window, and the clock ticks steadily in the background.

Cinematography:

Camera: medium close-up, slow push-in with gentle parallax from hanging tools

Lens: 35 mm virtual lens; shallow depth of field to soften background clutter

Lighting: warm key from overhead practical; cool spill from window for contrast

Mood: gentle, whimsical, a touch of suspense

Actions:

- The robot taps the bulb; sparks crackle.
- It flinches, dropping the bulb, eyes widening.

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Mood: nostalgic, tender, cinematic

Actions:

- She spins; her dress flares, catching sunlight.
- Woman (laughing): "See? Even the city dances with us tonight."
- He steps in, catches her hand, and dips her into shadow.
- Man (smiling): "Only because you lead."
- Sheets drift across frame, briefly veiling the skyline before parting again.

Background Sound:

Natural ambience only: faint wind, fabric flutter, street noise, muffled music. No added score.

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